



Ranked
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Soumya C.,
27, Arikere, Karnataka

Her mother is unlettered, but that didn't stop the zonal level sprinter from fulfilling her diplomatic dream

Sprinting to Success

The world of diplomacy always fascinated her. Polyglot diplomats playing great ambassadors. Track Two parleys by global intellectuals. For 27-year-old Soumya C., whose mother Narasamma is illiterate, growing up in a village Arikere near Srirangapatna—the island fortress where the Mysore warrior Tipu Sultan was murdered by the British in May 1799—in Mandya district, it could have remained a Technicolor dream. But for her father Chandrashekhara Chari, 62, a diploma holder who worked in the erstwhile Karnataka electricity board, sending his only daughter to school was a priority. Life was tough for her parents and even a decent meal was a luxury. But nothing could stop her either from consistently topping in school or excelling in Bharatanatyam

and salsa.

The young assistant commissioner posted at the Income Tax department in Chennai wanted to be a doctor but ended up with an engineering degree from Mandya. Encouraged by her brothers Satish and Chetan as well as her fiancé Praphullachandra Sharma, an IAS officer, she trained at Bangalore's Universal Coaching Centre. A zonal-level sprinter, she used technology to aid her study. "You just need six to seven hours of solid quality study time daily and that will take you through," is her advice to young civil services aspirants. Of course, "follow your heart's desire and work at it", she adds. "One must always aim to do the best and aim for the top," she says, particularly encouraging women to not just stop at scoring a high percentage in school, but to go beyond.

by Stephen David

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